Such a close examination of approximately eight–nine decades in the lifespan of the Shansabanis' confederate empire presents manifold additional avenues for inquiry. Among the foremost aims for the project at hand, however, is the untethering of scholarship on South and Central Asia's history of the second millennium CE from the apparently irresistible pull of a magnetic pole originating in pre-modern historiography, namely, the drive to write emphatically *Islamic* histories.

In the Arabic and Persian histories of the Islamic world dating roughly from the thirteenth through eighteenth centuries, we can justifiably observe that among their authors' pre-eminent drives was the adumbration of not only a "divinely ordained paradigm of the rise and fall of states," but specifically an *Islamically* ordained one.[15] Such a drive was plausibly even more pronounced on the perceived peripheries of this physical and moral world, as would have been the case in the environs of South and Central Asia. Arabic- and Persian-language authors writing about the region tended to treat the Shansabanis as one lock in the ever-lengthening, multi-stranded braid of *Muslim* dynasts. For some, the first lock of this braid would have been the Umayyad incursions of the eighth century, though the Ghaznavids might have shared this initiatory status particularly with regard to northern India.[16]

The continued presence of specifically *Islamic* dynastic lineages in South Asia was not lost on these historical authors (collectively): the above-mentioned braid of events continued its intricate and sinuous progress with the Shansabanis and then the so-called Delhi Sultanate (usually dated *c.* 1211–*c.* 1525 CE), which also engendered the creation of eventually independent states governed by confessionally Muslim elites throughout the Deccan. Ultimately, the advent of the Mughals and what were ostensibly the latter's successor states of the eighteenth century brought this Islamically ordained timeline into the very present of some of these authors.[17] In hindsight, then, even while the authors' presentation of the sequence of events was not strictly incorrect, their understanding of the Shansabanis' place in near-exclusively *Islamic* historical time arguably cleaved to the central purpose of writing an *Islamic* history. Furthermore, the composition of Islamic pasts was very much in keeping with the historical authors' moral universe(s), and the epistemological and literary conventions guiding their intellectual labors (see also Chapter 1, this volume).

Today, it is safe to say that the universes – moral and otherwise – providing the impetuses for scholarship are different, as are the epistemological and intellectual conventions guiding present-day authors. The seemingly inescapable urge to identify historical actors and processes within an Islamic, divinely ordained "history" does not *have* to be prevalent, and the need to legitimize a royal patron's rightful place in Islamic time and space is now obsolete. And yet – jarringly – the disciplinary specialties of "Islamic" history, art and architecture, archaeology, etc. have